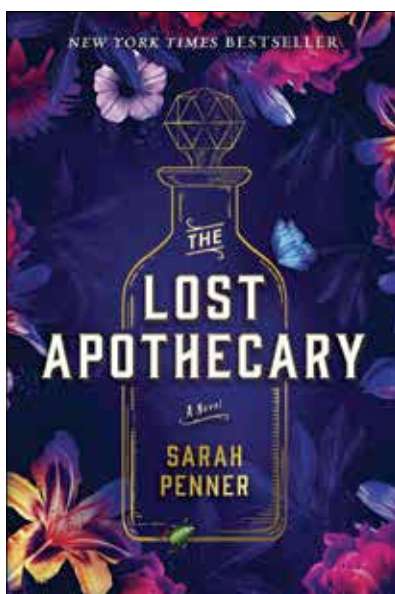


BOOK

The Lost Apothecary

★★★★☆ | Let us just subvert the idiom and judge this book by its cover. The golden bottle and the author's name is actually reflective, and looks like real gold has been inlaid into the book, catching the light in different ways. Then the title of the book, the butterfly and the beetle are all iridescent. If you run your fingers over them the insects are smooth to touch, while the golden bits are rough, making you wonder if it actually is gold. Inside the dust jacket is a jet black cover with silver details on the spine. Nella Clavinger runs the lost Apothecary, which is a hidden away refuge for oppressed women who use the gifts of nature to rid themselves of toxic men in their lives. Nella's newest customer is a



plucky 12 year old called Eliza Fanning, who makes a fatal error that may expose the apothecary and its register that contains the details of many women who have used the services of Nella. Cut to modern day London, we have the amateur historian and

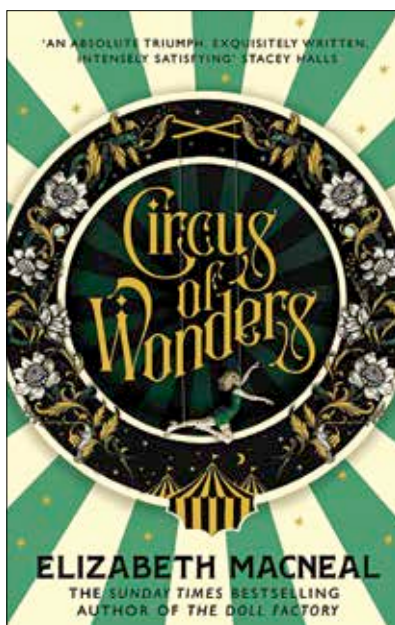
diligent researcher, Caroline Parcell who stumbles across a vial from the apothecary, during a despondent "mudlarking" tour looking for historical artefacts that wash up on the shores of the Thames. Caroline feels a connection to whoever last used the bottle, setting her off on an investigation that leads her to uncover the secrets of the Apothecary Murders that took place in London over two centuries ago. To be clear, this is not a fantasy title, but it is brimming with the magic of the psyche and intuition. The chapters move back and forth between present day London and Victorian London, with each period explored in its full trappings, from heartbreaking texts on instant messaging platforms and draining smartphone batteries in the present day to the handwritten notes and messenger boys in the past. It is a bittersweet read, stuffed with maps and notes and victoriana, the turmoil balanced with sudden bursts of unadulterated fun. This book is also beautiful on the inside.

—Aditya Madanapalle

BOOK

Circus of Wonders

★★★★☆ | Nell is a nineteen year old girl in a small village in coastal England, who does the backbreaking work of picking violets and candying them for a living. Since birth she has had mottled skin, and is considered to be bad luck by her father, who blames her for all the things that go wrong in their lives. Even those that are close to her shun her, and avoid touching her, and the only one who stands up for her is her brother, Charlie. A circus, run by the world famous Jasper Jupiter comes to visit the small village, causing the local population to be excited and the village idiot Lenny cruelly asks if Nell will be performing with the other living curiosities. The circus does come to visit, and Nell sees a change in her brother,



perhaps triggered by the cruel words of Lenny that turns out to be prophetic. Nell is betrayed by her family, and is sold off to the showman Jasper Jupiter as a "leopard girl". This exchange has both its benefits and pitfalls. On one

hand, the "freaks" who would have otherwise been shunned by society have a chance at riches, glory and fame. Nell fits right in, and what's more turns out to be an awesome performer. On the other hand, Jasper Jupiter is a hard taskmaster who keeps the entire crew under tight control with an iron fist. He even exerts his obnoxious power over his own younger sibling, Toby a budding war photographer at a time when photography itself was budding. The story is very much about power dynamics and the obscene ways in which people can control each other, but Toby's adventures in Crimea add an additional layer of relevance as censorship and the dissemination of fake news is also explored, in the very early days of mass media. This is a circus novel, so you know that it is going to be a riot right from the start, and the book does not disappoint in the least. If you liked the League of Extraordinary Gentlemen or Penny Dreadful, then this is something that you will definitely enjoy.

—Aditya Madanapalle